The Odyssey, Part Two

Annotated model · "The Enchantress Circe" (from Book 10)

Homer, translated by Robert Fitzgerald · textbook pages 743–745

Learning targets

9.RV.1.A I can figure out and use academic and content-specific words from the text: glossary words, words I can define from context, and literary terms such as *epic*, *simile*, and *allusion*.

9.RL.1.A I can explain a theme of the text and how its characters, setting, and plot develop that theme.

Reading the annotations

Vocabulary a word to define and use 9.RV.1.A · blue notes

Theme a line that raises a topic that develops a theme 9.RL.1.A · red notes

Character · Setting · Plot a detail that builds the theme 9.RL.1.A · red notes

Blue notes define words; the line under each uses a literary term (diction, connotation, imagery, allusion, point of view...). Red notes connect a detail to a theme: the numbered top line names the topic, character, setting, or plot detail, and the line under it explains how that detail builds the theme. Arrows point to the exact words.

Topic vs. theme. A topic names a subject (*temptation*). A theme carries a message or lesson about it (*giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most*). Each theme note names a topic; its number shows which theme that topic develops. The numbered themes are listed at the top of page 743. Teacher notes (theme development, discussion key, vocabulary key, model response) follow the passage.

Themes

1. Giving in to temptation can cost you what matters most.
2. Appearances can deceive: what looks lovely and welcoming can hide danger.
3. Caution can protect you, while trusting too easily can lead you into a trap.
4. Comfort and pleasure can make you forget your goals.

from

The Odyssey

An Epic Poem by **Homer**

Translated by **Robert Fitzgerald**

Vocab: epic = long poem of a hero's journey
Genre: an epic hero, a quest, and gods who step in.

Part Two: from Books 10–12

"The lovely voices in ardor appealing over the water made me crave to listen, and I tried to say 'Untie me!' to the crew, jerking my brows."

Vocab: ardor = burning passion
Diction: gives the Sirens' song a tempting connotation.

1. Topic: temptation
Even Odysseus begs to be untied, so no one is safe from temptation.

The Enchantress Circe (from Book 10)

Vocab: enchantress = woman who casts spells
Word analysis: enchant + -ress (female). An epithet for Circe.

After escaping the Cyclopes' island, Odysseus and his men land on the island of Aeolus (ē′ ə ləs), king of the winds. Aeolus assists him by putting all of the unfavorable winds in a bag, which he gives to Odysseus. His curious crew, however, rip open the bag, and

1. Character: the curious crew
A god's gift is in their hands, yet curiosity wins. Giving in costs them their goal.

the hurricane-like winds blow the ships far off course. In the days that follow, Odysseus and his men fight a battle with cannibals on Laestrygonia (les trig ō′ nē ə), in which they lose many men and all but one of their ships. Odysseus and his remaining men then arrive on the island of the goddess and sorceress Circe (sur′ sē). Though his men are fearful of what they may find there, Odysseus sends out a scouting party.

"In the wild wood they found an open glade
around a smooth stone house—the hall of Circe—
and wolves and mountain lions lay there, mild
in her soft spell, fed on her drug of evil.
None would attack—oh, it was strange, I tell you—
but switching their long tails they faced our men
like hounds, who look up when their master comes
with tidbits for them—as he will—from table.
Humbly those wolves and lions with mighty paws
fawned on our men—who met their yellow eyes
and feared them.

In the entrance way they stayed
to listen there: inside her quiet house
they heard the goddess Circe.

Low she sang
in her beguiling voice, while on her loom
she wove ambrosial fabric sheer and bright,
by that craft known to the goddesses of heaven.
No one would speak, until Polites—most
faithful and likable of my officers, said:

'Dear friends, no need for stealth: here's a young weaver
singing a pretty song to set the air
a-tingle on these lawns and paven courts.
Goddess she is, or lady. Shall we greet her?'

So reassured, they all cried out together,
and she came swiftly to the shining doors
to call them in. All but Eurylochus—
who feared a snare—the innocents went after her.
On thrones she seated them, and lounging chairs,
while she prepared a meal of cheese and barley
and amber honey mixed with Pramnian wine,
adding her own vile pinch, to make them lose
desire or thought of our dear father land.
Scarce had they drunk when she flew after them
with her long stick and shut them in a pigsty—

be • guil • ing (bi gī′ liŋ) *adj.*, outwardly charming but inwardly deceptive
stealth (stelth) *n.*, sneakiness; secretiveness

1. Plot: the cost
One moment of temptation blows them away from home.

2. Setting: a strange island
The men fear the unknown, so the calm glade is not what it seems.

2. Topic: appearance vs. reality
Setting: wild beasts act tame, a first hint that Circe's charm hides danger.

Vocab: simile = a "like" comparison
In Homer's Greek an epic simile ("As when dogs... so the wolves..."); the translation shortens it.

Vocab: narrator = who tells the story
Point of view: first person. Odysseus tells this in a flashback.

Vocab: fawned = acted like a pet
Connotation: flattering to please.

Vocab: ambrosial = fit for the gods
Allusion: ambrosia, food of the gods.

Vocab: beguiling = charming but deceptive
Indirect characterization of Circe; theme 2 in one word.

3. Character: trusting Polites
He trusts a pretty song and leads the men in. Easy trust walks them into the trap.

Vocab: stealth = sneakiness
Dramatic irony: we sense danger; Polites drops his guard.

3. Character: cautious Eurylochus
Fears a snare (trap) and stays out, so he is the only one spared.

Vocab: vile = evil, disgusting
Diction: the narrator's judgment sets a menacing mood.

4. Topic: forgetting home
Plot: her drug wipes out thoughts of home. Pleasure erases their goal.

bodies, voices, heads, and bristles, all swinish now, though minds were still unchanged. So, squealing, in they went. And Circe tossed them acorns, mast, and cornel berries—fodder for hogs who rut and slumber on the earth. Down to the ship Eurylochus came running to cry alarm, foul magic doomed his men![1] But working with dry lips to speak a word he could not, being so shaken; blinding tears welled in his eyes; foreboding filled his heart. When we were frantic questioning him, at last we heard the tale: our friends were gone. . . ."

Odysseus leaves the ship at once to confront Circe himself. Protected from her spells with help from Hermes, Odysseus convinces the goddess to restore his shipmates to their human form. Odysseus and his crew dally on Circe's island for a year. When Odysseus decides they must head home, Circe tells him he will not return safely unless he goes to the Land of the Dead to seek advice from the blind seer Teiresias.

1. **magic doomed his men.** Crew members enslaved by Circe's tricks

1. Topic: losing yourself
Plot: the men who gave in become pigs, minds trapped in animal bodies.

Vocab: mast = acorns & nuts
Context clue: listed with acorns and berries.

Vocab: fodder = animal feed
Context clue: "for hogs." Imagery of their animal state.

3. Plot: caution saved Eurylochus
Because he stayed out, he can warn the ship, and a rescue can begin.

Vocab: foreboding = sense of coming doom
Word analysis: fore- (before) + bode. Builds mood and suspense.

3. Character: the leader acts
Odysseus goes in protected by Hermes. Courage plus caution beats the trap.

Vocab: dally = linger, waste time
Connotation: idle delay that stalls the epic hero's quest.

4. Topic: forgetting home
Plot: a year of comfort passes before they think of home (l. 32–33).

Vocab: seer = one who sees the future
Word analysis: see + -er. Archetype: the blind prophet.

Teacher notes

How the themes develop · discussion key

How the themes develop 9.RL.1.A

Before the passage (p. 743). The epigraph shows even the hero tempted: the Sirens' song *"made me crave to listen."* In the summary, the crew's curiosity opens Aeolus's bag of winds, and a gift from a god blows them away from home. Theme 1

Beginning (lines 1–18). The setting looks welcoming: an *"open glade,"* a *"smooth stone house,"* and wolves and lions lying *"mild"* that fawn *"like hounds."* Circe sings in a *"beguiling"* voice and weaves *"ambrosial"* fabric. Every detail is lovely, yet the beasts are *"fed on her drug of evil."* Theme 2

Middle (lines 19–35). Polites, *"most faithful and likable,"* trusts a *"pretty song"* and says there is *"no need for stealth."* Only Eurylochus, *"who feared a snare,"* stays out. Circe's *"vile pinch"* makes the men *"lose desire or thought of our dear father land,"* and she pens them in a pigsty. Themes 3, 4, 1

End (lines 36–47 and summary). The men are *"swinish now, though minds were still unchanged"*: giving in costs them who they are. Eurylochus's caution lets him raise the alarm, and Odysseus confronts Circe protected by Hermes. Then the whole crew, Odysseus included, *"dally"* on the island for a year. Themes 1, 3, 4

Discussion key

I Do (lines 1–11). Think aloud about the setting: wolves and lions should attack, but they fawn *"like hounds"* (a simile; in Homer's Greek it is a full epic simile, which Fitzgerald shortens). Something is wrong here, the first sign that appearance and reality differ.

We Do (lines 12–24). Why does Polites trust Circe? She sings, she weaves, and she looks like a *"young weaver."* Is he foolish or just kind? Accept either side with evidence, then push to theme 3: easy trust leads the men into the trap.

We Do (lines 25–35). How is Eurylochus different from the *"innocents"*? What does the drug take from the men? (*"thought of our dear father land"*: their goal of home, theme 4.)

Partners (lines 36–47 and summary). Why is *"minds were still unchanged"* worse than a full change? (They know what they have lost.) Then: after the rescue, the crew stays a year. Does Odysseus fall for the same temptation he rescued them from?

Exit discussion. Choose one theme. Name a character, setting, or plot detail that develops it and explain how, using one vocabulary word from the passage.

Teacher notes

Vocabulary key · model response · watch for

Vocabulary key 9.RV.1.A

Glossary pair. Circe is *beguiling* (charming outside, deceptive inside). Polites says there is *"no need for stealth,"* but stealth is exactly what they need: **dramatic irony**, because readers already know she is an *enchantress*.

Context clues. *Mast* is listed with *"acorns"* and *"cornel berries"*; *fodder* is defined by *"for hogs."* Ask: which words around it tell you what it means?

Word analysis. *enchant* + *-ress* (a woman who casts spells); *fore-* + *bode* (a feeling before something bad); *see* + *-er* (one who sees the future). Find two more *-ess* words in the summary on page 744 (*goddess, sorceress*).

Literary terms in use. Simile (lines 7–8; an epic simile in Homer's Greek, shortened in translation), **allusion** (*ambrosial*: ambrosia, the food of the gods), **first-person point of view** (*"I tell you,"* line 5) in a **flashback**, and **connotation** (*vile, fawned, dally* carry judgment, not just meaning).

Use it. "Eurylochus is filled with *foreboding* as he runs back to the ship." "Instead of sailing home, the crew *dallies* on Circe's island for a year."

Model response

In "The Enchantress Circe," Homer develops the theme that appearances can deceive. The setting looks welcoming: wolves and mountain lions lie *"mild"* and fawn on the men *"like hounds,"* and Circe sings in a *"beguiling"* voice while weaving *"ambrosial"* fabric. Polites, *"most faithful and likable,"* trusts the *"pretty song"* and decides there is *"no need for stealth."* Only Eurylochus, *"who feared a snare,"* stays outside. Circe's warm welcome hides a *"vile pinch"* that makes the men forget *"our dear father land"* and turns them into pigs, *"though minds were still unchanged."* Because Eurylochus looked past the charming surface, he survives to warn Odysseus, showing that what seems lovely can hide a trap.

Watch for

Topic, not theme: push "deception" or "trust" to a full statement. **"Circe is just a villain":** the lesson is about the men's choices: trusting too quickly and giving in. **Eurylochus, coward or wise?** He is too shaken to speak, yet his caution saves the crew; Odysseus combines caution with courage (and Hermes' help). **Theme 4 turns on the hero:** after the rescue, Odysseus himself stays a year, so even leaders fall for comfort. **Modern connection:** a *beguiling* offer today, like a too-good-to-be-true deal or a friendly stranger online; ask what *stealth* (caution) looks like there. **Who is telling this?** Odysseus narrates to King Alcinous and calls his men *"innocents,"* so he may soften their mistakes.